1. Executive Summary — The “Why”

The 2026 job market is saturated with information but lacks **clarity**.

Job seekers face a **signal-to-noise problem**:

- Hundreds of job descriptions
- Conflicting skill expectations
- No clear prioritization of what actually matters

At the same time, hiring managers are overwhelmed with:

- Generic resumes
- Misaligned candidates
- Lack of demonstrated readiness

kestrel solves this by transforming unstructured inputs (job descriptions + resumes) into a clear, prioritized roadmap.

👉 It answers:

- *“How ready am I?”*
- *“What am I missing?”*
- *“What should I do next?”*

This is not a resume tool.
This is a **decision engine for career progression**.

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2. Target Personas

Persona 1 — Job-Seeking Student (Primary User)

Attribute	Details
Profile	Final-year student or early-career professional
Goals	Land competitive roles (PM, SE, SWE, etc.)
Pain Points	Overwhelmed by job requirements, unclear priorities, scattered prep

Behaviors	Applies to multiple roles, tweaks resume repeatedly, consumes online resources
Needs	Clear signal on readiness, actionable steps, efficient prep

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Persona 2 — Hiring Manager / Recruiter (Secondary Lens)

Attribute	Details
Goals	Quickly identify strong, role-ready candidates
Pain Points	Generic resumes, unclear skill alignment
What They Value	Candidates who demonstrate: • clarity • relevance • initiative
Opportunity	kestrel helps users *become* the candidate recruiters want

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3. Core User Stories (Messy → Clean)

Scenario	User Story
Input chaos	As a user, I want to paste a job description and upload my resume so I can compare them instantly
Insight generation	As a user, I want to see my readiness score so I understand how competitive I am
Gap clarity	As a user, I want to identify missing skills so I know what to improve
Resume improvement	As a user, I want AI-generated suggestions for what to add to my resume
Actionability	As a user, I want a clear plan of next steps so I don't waste time guessing
Transformation	As a user, I want to see a clear "before vs after" so I feel progress and clarity

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4. Functional Requirements

4.1 Input Layer — Dual Pane

Feature	Description
Job Description Input	Paste raw JD text
Resume Input	Upload or paste resume
Optional Notes	Add context (target role, timeline)

4.2 AI Analysis Engine

Capability	Description
Skill Extraction	Identify required vs existing skills
Readiness Score	% match between resume and JD
Gap Analysis	Highlight missing competencies
Semantic Matching	Handle messy, non-standard phrasing
Output Format	Structured JSON for frontend rendering

4.3 Bento Grid Dashboard (Core UI)

Component	Description
Readiness Score Card	Visual % + confidence indicator
Skill Gap Panel	Missing skills grouped by category
Strengths Panel	What user already does well
Resume Upgrade Suggestions	Bullet points to add/improve
Market Signals (Lite)	Keywords or trends from JD

👉 Design: modular, visually clean, card-based

4.4 Resume Optimization Engine

Feature	Description
Bullet Suggestions	AI-generated resume lines aligned to JD
Framing Suggestions	How to rephrase experience
Skill Injection	Keywords to include for ATS alignment

4.5 Next Steps Strategy Generator

Feature	Description
Action Plan	Ranked steps to close gaps
Learning Paths	Suggested certifications/resources
Time Estimates	Approx time to complete each step
Project Ideas	Portfolio suggestions tailored to role

4.6 Core Interaction Flow

1. User inputs messy data
2. Clicks **Analyze**
3. AI processes (live typing feedback)
4. UI transforms into structured dashboard
5. User explores insights + actions

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5. Technical Requirements & Constraints

Area	Requirement
Frontend	Next.js
Styling	Tailwind CSS
Deployment	Vercel
AI Layer	Gemini API

Data Handling	JSON-based structured outputs
Parsing	Resume text extraction (basic)
Performance	Fast response (<3–5s perceived via streaming)

Constraints

- Must handle **messy real-world text**
- AI output must be **consistent + parseable JSON**
- No heavy backend required (v1 can be stateless)

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6. UX / UI Design Principles

Core Principles

1. Messy → Clean Transformation

- Input = raw, chaotic
- Output = structured, calm

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2. Live Typing AI Moments

- AI “thinking” creates perceived intelligence
- Builds trust + engagement

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3. Bento Grid Layout

- Modular, scannable
- Encourages exploration
- Feels premium + modern

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4. Playful yet Linear Aesthetic

- Clean structure (Linear/Notion)
- Subtle futuristic elements (gradients, motion)

- Optional “game-like” elements:
    - progress bars
    - readiness levels

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5. Demo-First Design

Every screen should answer:
👉 *“Can I explain this in 10 seconds?”*

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7. Success Metrics (What Makes This Elite)

Metric	Definition
Clarity	User instantly understands their readiness
Transformation	Strong “before vs after” moment
Storytelling	Demo flows naturally and convincingly
UI Polish	Feels like a real product, not a student project
Relevance	Solves a real, relatable problem
Memorability	Recruiters remember it after 30 seconds

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8. Future Scope (v2 Vision)

Product Expansion

Feature	Description
Real-time Market Data	Salary + demand insights
Job Tracking Integration	Save and compare multiple roles
Browser Extension	Analyze jobs directly on LinkedIn
Continuous Profile	Track progress over time
AI Mock Interviews	Simulate recruiter questions

Technical Expansion

- User accounts (Supabase / Clerk)
- Persistent data storage
- Embedding-based matching
- Multi-role comparison engine

Final Positioning Statement

Kestrel is not a resume tool.
It is a **career intelligence system** that turns ambiguity into direction.

Visual Identity & Aesthetic System (Kestrel)

Visual Identity — “Pastel Strategic Futurism”

Kestrel adopts a **soft futuristic design language** that balances clarity with emotional resonance. The goal is to create an interface that feels:

- intelligent but calm
- structured but atmospheric
- modern but memorable

Rather than using traditional SaaS aesthetics (dark mode, neon, or corporate blue), Kestrel is inspired by **pastel sci-fi environments, horizon-based compositions, and layered pixel dreamscapes**.

Core Design Intent

- Transform chaos into clarity through **visual calmness**
- Represent progress through **directional, horizon-based metaphors**
- Maintain **high readability and product credibility** while introducing subtle personality

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Visual Metaphors

Concept	Representation
Career progression	Distant horizon / destination
Current state	Foreground / input layer
Insight generation	Light beams / signal highlights
AI intelligence	Subtle glow, live typing, system overlays
Decision-making	Structured modular panels

Aesthetic Principles

1. Messy → Clean Transformation

- Input areas appear raw and unstructured
- Output transitions into organized, modular layouts

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2. Layered Interface System

- Background (atmospheric gradient)
- Surface (panels/cards)
- Content (text/data)
- Signals (highlights, accents)

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3. Calm Intelligence

- Avoid visual noise

- Use soft contrast instead of harsh contrast
- Emphasize clarity over decoration

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4. Playful but Controlled

- Subtle game-like elements (progress, states, levels)
- Never compromise professionalism or readability

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5. Demo-First Visual Hierarchy

- Each screen must communicate value within 10 seconds
- Key insights (readiness, gaps, next steps) must dominate visually

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Motion & Interaction Principles

- Smooth, low-friction transitions
- Live typing AI feedback for perceived intelligence
- Gradual reveal of structured insights
- No aggressive animations or distractions

Positioning Statement

Kestrel feels like a **calm mission-control system for career decisions**, guiding users from uncertainty toward a clear, actionable future.

🎨 KESTREL DESIGN SYSTEM (BUILD-READY)

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1. Color System

Core Colors

Token	Hex	Usage
bg-primary	#F6F1E7	Main background
bg-gradient-start	#F7C7D4	Top gradient
bg-gradient-end	#C9B6E4	Bottom gradient
surface-primary	rgba(255,255,255,0.6)	Cards
surface-secondary	rgba(255,255,255,0.3)	Secondary panels
text-primary	#3C4166	Main text
text-secondary	#6B6F8E	Subtext

Accent Colors

Token	Hex	Usage
accent-primary	#4FA7A7	Primary CTA
accent-secondary	#7ED7F7	Interactive states
accent-highlight	#E87BF1	AI / insights

success	#C8F5DF	Positive signals
warning	#FF8FA3	Skill gaps

Gradient System

Use soft gradients, not harsh contrasts:

```
background: linear-gradient(
 135deg,
 #F7C7D4 0%,
 #F6F1E7 40%,
 #C9B6E4 100%
);
```

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2. Typography System

Font Stack

Primary:

- Inter (clean, readable, product-standard)

Optional accent:

- Space Grotesk (for headers if you want more personality)

Type Scale

Role	Size	Weight

Hero	32–40px	600
Section Title	20–24px	600
Card Title	16–18px	500
Body	14–16px	400
Caption	12–13px	400

Typography Rules

- No heavy bold blocks
- Keep spacing generous
- Use contrast through size, not weight

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3. Layout System

Grid

- 12-column responsive grid
- Max width: 1200px–1280px

Spacing Scale

Token	Value
xs	4px

sm	8px
md	16px
lg	24px
xl	32px
xxl	48px

Bento Grid (Core Layout)

- Large primary card (Readiness Score)
- Medium cards (Skill gaps, strengths)
- Small cards (actions, suggestions)

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4. Component System

Card Component

background: rgba(255,255,255,0.6);

backdrop-filter: blur(12px);

border-radius: 16px;

border: 1px solid rgba(255,255,255,0.3);

Usage:

- All dashboard modules
- Keep padding consistent (16–24px)

Primary Button

background: #4FA7A7;

color: white;

border-radius: 12px;

padding: 10px 16px;

Hover:

- Slight brightness increase
- Subtle glow

Input Fields

- Soft background
- No harsh borders
- Focus state = accent glow

Readiness Score Component

- Circular or large numeric display
- Color-coded:
    - Green → strong
    - Yellow → moderate
    - Coral → weak

Skill Gap Tags

- Rounded pills
- Use warning color
- Small + scannable

AI Typing Block

- Monospace or slightly different styling
- Animated text appearance
- Cursor blink effect

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5. Motion Guidelines

- Duration: 200–400ms
- Easing: ease-in-out
- Use:
    - fade-in
    - slight upward motion
    - blur → sharp transitions

Avoid:

- bounce
- aggressive scaling
- flashy effects

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6. Visual Effects

Use sparingly:

- soft glow (AI outputs)
- gradient overlays
- subtle noise texture (optional)
- faint grid lines (background)

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7. Design Rules (Non-Negotiables)

DO

- prioritize clarity
- keep layouts breathable
- use color intentionally
- make key insights dominant

DO NOT

- overload with colors
- use harsh black backgrounds
- overuse glassmorphism
- sacrifice readability for style

Final Design Definition

Kestrel = Dreamcore Mission Control

A structured, intelligent system wrapped in a soft, atmospheric interface that guides users from chaos to clarity.